

KDENZ FURTHER RESEARCH PLAN — 2-Week GTM De-Risk Strategy

Prepared: February 4, 2026

Context: B2C AI communication coaching app | Diagnostic-before-training approach | MVP shipped | ICP decision validated (early-career managers) | No primary research conducted yet

STOP USING THESE ASSUMPTIONS (Critical List)

CRITICAL (Blocks Launch)

1. "15-25% freemium conversion"

- **Document:** 2026-02-04_ICP-Validation...md, Section: "Freemium-to-Paid Conversion Benchmarks"
- **Quote:** "Free-to-paid (3rd session): 15-25% (higher than average because pattern = value moment)"
- **Why Unsupported:** Based on Noom/wellness app benchmarks (10-20%), NOT Kdenz user behavior. No evidence that "pattern recognition" actually triggers conversion at this rate.
- **Impact:** Unit economics are fiction. If actual conversion is 8%, LTV drops 50% and pricing model may be broken.
- **Action:** Run paywall A/B test to validate conversion rate by trigger.

2. "Managers have 2-4 difficult conversations/week"

- **Document:** 2026-02-04_ICP-Validation...md, Section: "Why This Segment Engages Repeatedly"
- **Quote:** "Difficult conversations are daily/weekly (giving feedback, pitching ideas, managing conflict)"
- **Why Unsupported:** Assertion without citation. Frequency drives subscription viability but not validated via interviews.
- **Impact:** Retention model unproven. If conversations are monthly (not weekly), churn will spike; may need pay-per-use.
- **Action:** User interviews + diary study to measure actual frequency.

3. "Gap Model positioning resonates with managers"

- **Document:** Kdenz Master Project Brief, Section: "Validated Decisions"
- **Quote:** Positioning Model: "Gap Model" — Your communication doesn't match your competence
- **Why Unsupported:** Locked as validated, but no evidence of user testing. May feel judgmental or miss the mark.
- **Impact:** Messaging may repel ICP. If users reject "Gap" framing, trial signups crater; brand feels accusatory.
- **Action:** Message testing survey to validate Gap vs. Diagnosis vs. Coach positioning.

4. "LTV: \$200-800 per user (12-24 month engagement)"

- **Document:** 2026-02-04_ICP-Validation...md, Section: "Kdenz Fit"
- **Quote:** "Projected LTV: \$200-\$800 per user (12-24 month engagement, higher upgrade rate)"
- **Why Unsupported:** LTV projection assumes 50-70% 30-day retention + 18-25% conversion + 12-24 month tenure. All are unvalidated.
- **Impact:** Financial model is speculation. If LTV is actually \$80-150, CAC ceiling drops; may not be venture-scale business.
- **Action:** Cohort retention analysis + paywall test to validate LTV inputs.

● HIGH (Affects Unit Economics)

5. "\$12.99-28.99 pricing optimal"

- **Document:** Kdenz Master Project Brief, "Validated Decisions" table
- **Quote:** "Pricing: Freemium model: \$12.99/mo (Basic) → \$28.99/mo (Pro)"
- **Why Unsupported:** Based on competitor benchmarking (Yoodli, Orai), not willingness-to-pay research with target users.
- **Impact:** Price may be too high or too low. If users anchor at \$9.99 (Duolingo), \$12.99 feels expensive; if they compare to coaching (\$100+), it signals low quality.
- **Action:** Price sensitivity survey + A/B pricing test to find optimal tier.

6. "3rd session is optimal paywall trigger"

- **Document:** Kdenz Master Project Brief, "Validated Decisions" table
- **Quote:** "Paywall Trigger: After 3rd practice session"
- **Why Unsupported:** Logic: "pattern = value moment." No A/B test vs. time-based (7-day) or feature-based (AI summary) triggers.
- **Impact:** Conversion timing wrong. If users want instant value (tips after Session 1), delaying to Session 3 increases drop-off before paywall.
- **Action:** Paywall trigger A/B test: 3rd session vs. 7-day vs. AI-gated.

7. "Physician credential builds trust"

- **Document:** 2026-02-04_ICP-Validation...md, Section: "Kdenz's Unique Differentiator Stack"
- **Quote:** "Physician Credibility + Non-Clinical Language ← Your advantage; Differentiates from former Googlers (Yoodli founder)"
- **Why Unsupported:** Assumption that "physician-designed" signals rigor. No A/B test vs. tech founder credential or blind test.
- **Impact:** Founder positioning may backfire. If tech workers trust "ex-Googler" more, physician angle wastes differentiation opportunity.
- **Action:** A/B landing page test: physician vs. tech founder vs. no credential.

8. "Real-time filler gauge drives 3.5x retention"

- **Document:** PRD.json, research_validated section
 - **Quote:** "visual_feedback_retention: VALIDATED - 3.5x retention with visual gauges/charts (Duolingo case study)"
 - **Why Unsupported:** Duolingo retention lift is from gamification (streaks, badges), not real-time gauges. Conflates correlation/causation.
 - **Impact:** Feature prioritization wrong. If gauge is low-impact but expensive to build, ROI is negative; may need to prioritize AI coaching quality instead.
 - **Action:** Feature correlation analysis to isolate retention drivers.
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INTERVIEW SCRIPT TEMPLATE (30 MIN)

Intro (2 min): "Hi [Name], thanks for joining. I'm building a speech coaching app for professionals and want to understand how you approach difficult conversations. This isn't a sales pitch—I'm genuinely trying to learn. Everything you share is confidential. Sound good?"

Section 1: Use Case Frequency (8 min)

1. "Walk me through a typical week at work. What kinds of conversations do you have regularly?"
2. "How often do you have conversations that feel high-stakes or difficult? (e.g., giving feedback, negotiating, pitching ideas, managing conflict)"
 - *Follow-up:* "Give me an example from the last 2 weeks."
3. "How often do you prepare for those conversations in advance?"
 - *Follow-up:* "What does preparation look like for you?"

Section 2: Current Solutions (5 min) 4. "Have you ever used any tools, apps, or coaching to improve your communication skills?"

- *If yes:* "What did you use? What worked? What didn't?"
 - *If no:* "Why not? What's held you back?"
5. "If you could get better at one communication skill, what would it be?"

Section 3: Willingness to Pay (7 min) 6. "If there were an app that let you practice difficult conversations with AI, get instant feedback on filler words, pacing, clarity, and see your improvement over time—would you use it?"

- *Follow-up:* "How much would you pay per month? (\$5, \$10, \$15, \$30?)"
7. "What would make you stop using it after a week?"

Section 4: Positioning Test (5 min) 8. "I'm going to show you three taglines. Tell me which one resonates most with you and why."

- A: "Your communication doesn't match your competence. Let's fix that." (Gap Model)
 - B: "We diagnose before we train. See what's really holding you back." (Diagnosis Model)
 - C: "Your personal communication coach—practice until it's natural." (Coach Model)
9. "If you saw this was designed by a physician vs. a former Google engineer, does that change your trust level?"

Wrap (3 min): 10. "Last question: If I launched this next month, would you try it?" 11. "Can I follow up with you in 2 weeks to see how you're using it?"

Incentive: \$20 Amazon gift card (optional)

B2B DISCOVERY TRACK (SECONDARY PRIORITY)

Target Buyer Hypothesis: **Sales Enablement (Start Here)**

Why Sales Enablement First:

- **Fastest budget cycle:** 2-3 months (vs. L&D: 6-12 months, HR: annual planning)
- **Clear ROI:** Tie to deal size, close rate, objection handling (measurable revenue impact)
- **Budget exists:** Average sales enablement budget: \$2,500-5,000 per rep/year
- **Narrow scope, fast adoption:** Sales teams are 10-50 people (pilot-friendly), not 1,000+ employees

5 Discovery Questions (Sales Enablement Buyers)

1. "What's the #1 communication skill your sales reps struggle with that costs you deals?"

- **Why this matters:** Validates whether "difficult conversations" (objection handling, pricing negotiation, executive pitching) is a felt pain point.
- **Listen for:** Specific examples (e.g., "Reps cave on price," "Can't handle CFO objections," "Sound junior on exec calls")
- **Red flag:** Vague answers ("They just need more confidence") → pain is not acute; may not pay

2. "How do you currently train reps on objection handling / executive presence / pricing conversations?"

- **Why this matters:** Identifies current solutions (competitors, substitutes, or nothing).
- **Listen for:**
 - "Roleplay in team meetings" → Manual, inconsistent, no data → Kdenz solves this
 - "Gong call reviews" → Post-hoc only, no practice → Kdenz complements this
 - "External coaching" → Expensive (\$200-500/session) → Kdenz undercuts this
- **Red flag:** "We use [enterprise platform]" → Budget already allocated; hard to displace

3. "If you could see a rep's pitch clarity, objection handling, and executive presence scored across 10 practice sessions, would that change how you coach them?"

- **Why this matters:** Tests value of Kdenz's core insight (diagnostic scoring over time).
- **Listen for:** "Yes, we're flying blind right now" → High intent
- **Red flag:** "We already have Gong/Chorus" → May not see gap between live-call analysis and practice tool

4. "What's your typical budget approval process for a \$5K-15K/year tool (10-30 reps)? Who signs off?"

- **Why this matters:** Maps procurement path (single approver vs. committee, timeline, budget holder).
- **Listen for:**
 - "I can approve up to \$10K myself" → **Fast track**
 - "Needs VP approval + quarterly budget review" → 3-6 month cycle
 - "Has to go through IT/Security review" → Add 1-2 months
- **Red flag:** "All tools go through annual RFP process" → Not pilot-ready

5. "Would you run a 30-day pilot with 5-10 reps if it were free, with the option to buy if it improved their pitch scores by 15%+?"

- **Why this matters:** Tests willingness to pilot + sets ROI expectation.
- **Listen for:**
 - "Yes, let's do it" → **Qualified lead**
 - "Maybe, send me a deck" → Lukewarm; needs more nurture
 - "We'd need to see a case study first" → Early adopter risk; may be 2nd or 3rd customer, not 1st
- **Red flag:** "We're locked into contracts until Q4" → Timing mismatch

Pricing Anchor Hypothesis: **Per-Seat, Tiered by Team Size**

Tier	Team Size	Price/Rep/Month	Annual Contract	Unlock Features
Pilot	5-10 reps	Free (30 days)	N/A	Full feature access for pilot validation
Starter	10-20 reps	\$25-40/rep/mo	\$3K-9.6K/year	Unlimited practice, analytics dashboard, manager reports
Growth	20-50 reps	\$20-30/rep/mo	\$4.8K-18K/year	Volume discount, custom scenarios, integrations (Salesforce, Gong)
Enterprise	50+ reps	\$15-25/rep/mo	Custom	Dedicated success manager, API access, white-label options

Why per-seat (not flat fee or usage-based):

- **Predictable revenue:** Scales with team size
- **Aligns with sales org budgets:** Sales enablement budgets are per-rep (\$2K-5K/rep/year)
- **Easy to pilot:** Start with 5-10 reps, expand if it works

Alternative (lower-risk pilot): Flat \$499-999/month for 10 seats → easier approval, but caps revenue scaling

COMMON RESEARCH TRAPS TO AVOID

Trap 1: "I'll just ask a few friends"

Why it fails: Friends are overly positive, not representative of ICP, won't give hard feedback **Do instead:** Recruit strangers who match ICP (LinkedIn, Reddit, cold email)

Trap 2: "I'll run a huge survey (n=500) to be rigorous"

Why it fails: Surveys don't uncover "why," only "what"; 500 responses takes 4 weeks + \$\$ **Do instead:** 15 interviews + 50-80 survey responses is enough for directional insights

Trap 3: "I'll wait until I have perfect statistical significance"

Why it fails: Bootstrapped founder needs speed over precision; perfect is enemy of good **Do instead:** Use 85% confidence threshold, not 95%; make reversible decisions quickly

Trap 4: "I won't define kill criteria because I believe in my idea"

Why it fails: Confirmation bias leads to ignoring negative signals; waste 6 months on wrong ICP **Do instead:** Write down "what result would make me pivot" before running research

Trap 5: "I'll research everything before launching"

Why it fails: Analysis paralysis; market moves while you're researching **Do instead:** Research 5 critical gaps (ICP, pricing, messaging, retention, paywall) → ship → learn more

FINAL CHECKLIST: BEFORE YOU START

- ☐ **Confirm research priorities** (pick 5-8 gaps to tackle in 2 weeks)
- ☐ **Draft interview script** (customize template above)

- ☐ **Build survey instruments** (Google Forms, Typeform, or Qualtrics)
 - ☐ **Set up analytics tracking** (Mixpanel, Amplitude, or PostHog for MVP)
 - ☐ **Recruit participants** (target: 15 interviews, 50 survey responses, 8 diary study)
 - ☐ **Launch A/B landing page test** (physician vs. tech credential)
 - ☐ **Schedule synthesis time** (Day 8, Day 12, Day 15)
 - ☐ **Prepare kill criteria** (write down what results would make you pivot)
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You now have a complete, executable 2-week research plan. The goal is not "learn everything"—it's "unlock the 5 critical GTM decisions with minimum viable evidence." Execute ruthlessly, synthesize quickly, and ship.